

DWAYNE & QIANA

Where are we waking up?

Thursday, October 1 → Sunday, October 4, 2026 · three nights

You said overwater bungalow. So I went and found every single one we can actually reach from Chicago in three nights, priced them out, and threw away the ones that don't work. Here they are. Pick one.

OPTION SET 1

We fly

Four that fit three nights, and four that look great until you check the flight.

RIVIERA MAYA · MEXICO

MY PICK

Palafitos

at El Dorado Maroma · adults only

Fly from Midway, nonstop

In the air 3h 40m

Airport to room 45 to 60 min drive

Door to door about 7 hours

All inclusive Yes, plus butler

ESTIMATED TOTAL, ALL IN

\$4,300 to \$4,800

Thirty thatched bungalows on stilts over the water at Maroma Beach. Glass floor panel in the room, your own infinity pool on the deck, outdoor shower, ladder straight down into the sea. **These are the only true overwater bungalows in Mexico.** Leave Midway in the morning, be in the water by afternoon.

Easiest trip

Adults only

Seaweed possible

ARUBA

Aruba Ocean Villas

Savaneta · boutique, couples

Fly from O'Hare, nonstop

In the air about 5h

Airport to room 20 to 25 min drive

Door to door 7 to 8 hours

All inclusive No, meals extra

ESTIMATED TOTAL, ALL IN

\$3,500 to \$4,200

Thatched villas over clear shallow water on the quiet south end, far from the high rise strip. Hardwood decks, ladders into the sea. **Aruba sits outside the hurricane belt**, so early October there is just a normal beach week instead of a gamble. Cheapest of the good ones.

Best weather odds

Lowest price

O'Hare only

BELIZE

Thatch Caye

a Muy'Ono Resort · private island

Fly from O'Hare, likely 1 stop

Then Puddle jumper + speedboat

Door to door about 12 hours

Usable time roughly 1.5 of 3 days

All inclusive Yes, transfers too

ESTIMATED TOTAL, ALL IN

\$3,600 to \$6,200

Fifteen overwater bungalows on a private island inside the barrier reef. Genuinely beautiful, and the one we originally saw. **But October is Belize's wettest month, about ten inches of rain, at the peak of hurricane season,** and reef boat trips get cancelled. This is a February trip, not an October one.

Worst month

Two travel days

BOCAS DEL TORO · PANAMA

Azul Paradise

overwater bungalows on the lagoon

Fly from O'Hare + 2nd flight

Then Boat to the island

Door to door about 14 hours

Usable time roughly 1.5 of 3 days

All inclusive Yes, on the package

ESTIMATED TOTAL, ALL IN

\$2,750 to \$3,200

Ten bungalows on stilts over a turquoise lagoon, glass floor panel, private sundeck, hammock hanging over the water. **By far the cheapest real overwater bungalow on this list.** The catch is two of our three days go to airports, and the vibe is rustic barefoot rather than luxury.

Cheapest overall

Rustic

Two travel days

BELIZE · PREMIUM

Cayo Espanto

Casa Ventanas · private island, 7 villas

Door to door about 12 hours

All inclusive Yes, private butler

Included 3 meals, drinks, sailboat

Extra charges 9% tax + 15% island fee

ESTIMATED TOTAL, ALL IN

\$11,500 to \$14,000

A bungalow floating at the end of a 150 foot dock with its own butler and sailboat. Honestly **the best property on this entire page.** It is also the worst possible month to go, so my advice is to keep this one in our back pocket for February or March and give it five or six nights instead of three.

Most special

Wrong month

ST. LUCIA

Sandals Grande St. Lucian

over the water butler bungalows

Fly from No October nonstop

Door to door 9 to 10 hours

All inclusive Yes, plus 3 resorts

Adults only Yes

ESTIMATED TOTAL, ALL IN

\$7,100 to \$7,900

Beautiful bungalows and you get run of three Sandals resorts on the island. **The problem is purely arithmetic:** with a connection each way, two of our three days become travel days. Worth it for a week. Not worth it for three nights.

Full butler

Bad flight math

ST. VINCENT

Sandals Saint Vincent

two story overwater villas

Fly from No nonstop, usually 2 stops

Door to door 12 to 14 hours

All inclusive Yes

Adults only Yes

ESTIMATED TOTAL, ALL IN

\$11,500 to \$13,500

The newest and arguably the nicest overwater villas Sandals has built, two full stories out over the water. **Also the hardest to get to on the whole list.** Two connections each way means we would spend more time in airports than in the villa.

Newest villas

Two full travel days

JAMAICA

Sandals Jamaica

Royal Caribbean & South Coast

Fly from Midway route is Nov to Apr

Status Closed / renovating

Reopens December 18, 2026

AVAILABILITY

Not an option

Including it so you know I checked. **Royal Caribbean is closed until December 18, 2026** and reopening under a new name, South Coast is mid way through a \$200M rebuild after Hurricane Melissa, and the Midway to Montego Bay flight is a winter only route that does not run in October. Three strikes.

Unavailable

SIDE BY SIDE

The numbers, if you want them

Swipe sideways on your phone. Gold column is my pick.

	RIVIERA MAYA	ARUBA	BELIZE	PANAMA	ST. LUCIA
Property	Palafitos	Aruba Ocean Villas	Thatch Caye	Azul Paradise	Sandals Grande
Fly out of	Midway, nonstop	O'Hare, nonstop	O'Hare, 1 stop	O'Hare, 2 flights	O'Hare, 2 flights
Time in the air	3h 40m	about 5h	4h 22m to 7h	6h 30m plus boat	7h plus connect
Door to door	about 7 hours	7 to 8 hours	about 12 hours	about 14 hours	9 to 10 hours
Usable time	nearly all 3 days	nearly all 3 days	about 1.5 days	about 1.5 days	about 1.5 days
Per night	\$1,100 to \$1,250	\$549 to \$1,579	\$600 to \$1,200	\$375 to \$450	\$1,900 to \$2,022
All inclusive	Yes, plus butler	No	Yes	Yes, on package	Yes, plus
Flights for two	about \$800	\$1,000 to \$1,400	\$1,200 to \$1,600	\$1,400 to \$1,800	\$1,400 to \$1,800
Total, 3 nights	\$4,300 to \$4,800	\$3,500 to \$4,200	\$3,600 to \$6,200	\$2,750 to \$3,200	\$7,100 to \$7,900
Early Oct weather	Rain fading	Dry, 82 to 88°F	Wettest month	Wet season	Rainy season
Hurricane risk	Moderate, falling	Essentially none	Peak	Outside the belt	Moderate
Adults only	Yes	Couples focused	No	No	Yes
The catch	Seaweed is possible	Meals not included	Wrong month entirely	Two travel days	Two travel days

We cruise

Cheaper than every land option, but read the date note first.

First, the honest problem with our dates

Almost every 3 night cruise sails **Friday to Monday**. October 1 is a Thursday. So most of the good ones want us to slide one day, leaving **Friday October 2 and coming home Monday October 5**. That costs one Monday off work. There is exactly one 3 night cruise that sails our exact dates, and it is the first card below.

PORT CANAVERAL · 3 NIGHTS

OUR EXACT DATES

MSC Seashore

Thu Oct 1 → Sun Oct 4 · Nassau + Ocean Cay

Leaves Thu Oct 1, 5:00 PM

Back Sun Oct 4, 7:00 AM

Fly from Midway to Orlando

Nonstops a day 6 to 8

Overwater None

CRUISE FARE FOR TWO, TAXES IN

\$500 to \$740

The only cruise in the world that sails our exact anniversary dates. No day off work, no shifting anything. Nassau on Friday, then Ocean Cay, MSC's private island in the Bahamas, on Saturday. Add about \$102 in tips. It is also the cheapest thing on this entire page by a mile. The tradeoff is that Ocean Cay has no overwater anything.

No date change

Cheapest

No overwater

PORT CANAVERAL · 3 NIGHTS

THE OVERWATER ONE

Utopia of the Seas

Royal Caribbean · Fri Oct 2 → Mon Oct 5

Leaves Fri Oct 2, 4:00 PM

Back Mon Oct 5, 6:00 AM

Fly from Midway to Orlando

CocoCay day Sunday Oct 4

Overwater Yes, a real one

CRUISE FARE FOR TWO, TAXES IN

\$2,420 to \$2,620

This is the one that actually gives you the overwater bungalow. On Sunday the ship docks at Perfect Day at CocoCay and you can book a **Coco Beach Club Overwater Cabana**. Only twenty of them exist in the entire Royal Caribbean fleet. 675 square feet standing out over the water, a private slide that drops you straight into the ocean, a hammock hanging over the water, your own wet bar and attendant. Priced per cabana, not per person.

Real overwater cabana

One day shift

Big busy ship

FORT LAUDERDALE · 3 NIGHTS

Jewel of the Seas

Royal Caribbean · Fri Oct 2 → Mon Oct 5

Ship size 2,100 guests

CocoCay day Sunday Oct 4

Fly from Midway to Fort Lauderdale

Nonstops a day Only 1 useful morning one

Overwater Yes, same cabana

CRUISE FARE FOR TWO, TAXES IN

\$930 to \$1,230

The same overwater cabana at CocoCay, on a ship a third the size, for less than half the fare. Utopia carries 5,668 people. This one carries 2,100, which means no waterslide crowds and a much more grown up feel. The catch is the flight. There is really only one useful morning nonstop from Midway to Fort Lauderdale, so we would fly in the night before.

Same cabana, half price

Quiet ship

Thin flights

PORT CANAVERAL · 3 NIGHTS

Carnival Glory

Fri Oct 2 → Mon Oct 5 · Celebration Key

Island day Saturday Oct 3

Fly from Midway to Orlando

Night before Not needed

Adults only spot Pearl Cove, 18+

Overwater Over the lagoon

CRUISE FARE FOR TWO, TAXES IN

\$850 to \$1,450

Carnival's brand new private destination, Celebration Key, has **Over-the-Lagoon Cabanas** built out over the water, about \$518 for the cabana for six hours. There is also Pearl Cove Beach Club, adults only, with a heated infinity pool. **The quiet advantage here is we do not need to fly down the night before.** Midway to Orlando runs six to eight times a day, so a morning flight still makes the ship comfortably.

No extra hotel night

Adults only beach club

Lagoon, not ocean

MIAMI · 3 NIGHTS

Norwegian Getaway

Fri Oct 2 → Mon Oct 5 · Great Stirrup Cay

Island day Sunday Oct 4

Fly from Midway to Miami

Nonstops a day About 1

Night before Basically required

Overwater Swings, not a cabana

CRUISE FARE FOR TWO, TAXES IN

\$518 to \$758

The most adults-only feeling of the mainstream ships. Vibe Beach Club onboard is 18 and over with its own bar and hot tubs, and Great Stirrup Cay has Silver Cove, a private lagoon area with overwater swings and a gazebo. Very cheap. The real problem is the flight: Midway to Miami is about one nonstop a day, so if it goes bad there is no recovery and the ship leaves without us.

Best adults only

Very cheap

Risky flight

FORT LAUDERDALE · 4 NIGHTS

Disney Destiny

Thu Oct 1 → Mon Oct 5 · Castaway Cay

Leaves Thu Oct 1, 3:00 PM

Nights 4

Theme Halloween on the High Seas

Adults only Zones only

Overwater None anywhere

CABIN FOR TWO, TAXES IN

\$2,242 to \$3,282

Newest ship in the Disney fleet and **it actually leaves on our anniversary date.** Nassau, then Castaway Cay with Serenity Bay, the adults only beach. The ship is decorated for Halloween the whole trip. Two honest problems: Disney has zero overwater anything anywhere in its fleet, and it is a family line, so we would be sharing the ship with a lot of kids.

Leaves Oct 1

4 nights, not 3

No overwater

The cruises side by side

Swipe sideways. Gold columns are the two worth serious thought.

	MSC SEASHORE	UTOPIA	JEWEL	CARNIVAL GLORY	NCL GETAWAY
Leaves from	Port Canaveral	Port Canaveral	Fort Lauderdale	Port Canaveral	Miami
Our dates?	Yes, exactly	One day later	One day later	One day later	One day later
Sails	Thu Oct 1	Fri Oct 2	Fri Oct 2	Fri Oct 2	Fri Oct 2
Nights	3	3	3	3	3
Overwater	None	Cabana at CocoCay	Cabana at CocoCay	Over the lagoon	Over the lagoon
Fly from Midway to	Orlando	Orlando	Fort Lauderdale	Orlando	Miami
Nonstops a day	6 to 8	6 to 8	1 useful	6 to 8	About 6 to 8
Hotel night before	Optional	Recommended	Recommended	Not needed	Required
Ship size	4,540	5,668	2,100	2,980	3,960
Fare for two	\$500 to \$740	\$2,420 to \$2,620	\$930 to \$1,230	\$850 to \$1,450	\$518 to \$758
Tips for two	\$102	\$111	\$111	\$102	\$120
Best thing	Our exact dates, cheapest	The real overwater cabana	Same cabana, quiet ship	No extra hotel night	Most fun feeling

My blunt read on cruising

A cruise is cheaper than every land option on this page, by a lot. Three nights on MSC Seashore for two of us is under \$750 including taxes, against about \$3,400 in room charges alone at Palafitos. Even the expensive Utopia is less than the bungalow.

But a cruise cannot give you the actual dream. An overwater cabana at CocoCay is six or seven hours on a Sunday with a ship full of people a few hundred yards away. An overwater bungalow is three nights of waking up over the water with nobody around. Those are different things and I do not want to pretend otherwise.

Where a cruise genuinely wins is weather. A resort sits still and takes whatever October sends it. A ship simply moves, so storms mean a swapped port rather than a ruined trip. Worth knowing too: 2026 has been a historically quiet Atlantic season, and as of today the hurricane center expects no new storms forming for at least a week.

So, pick one

You do not have to weigh all of that. Here is the short version, in the order I would choose.

1. **Riviera Maya.** If the experience is the point. Only one where we leave Midway in the morning and are in the water that afternoon.
2. **Aruba.** If you want zero weather anxiety. Outside the hurricane belt, cheapest of the good ones, we just pay for our own dinners.
3. **Panama.** If price is the point and you do not mind roughing the travel.
4. **Cayo Espanto.** Not now. Let's save this one and do it right in February.

Say a name and I will book it.

YOUR TURN

Tell me what you think

Type wherever you want. It saves as you go, so you can close this and come back.

Which one are you drawn to?

☐ Palafitos, Riviera Maya

☐ Aruba Ocean Villas

☐ Thatch Caye, Belize

☐ Azul Paradise, Panama

☐ Cayo Espanto, Belize

☐ Sandals St. Lucian

☐ Sandals St. Vincent

☐ Cruise: MSC Seashore

☐ Cruise: Utopia of the Seas

☐ Cruise: Jewel of the Seas

☐ Cruise: Carnival Glory

☐ Cruise: Norwegian Getaway

☐ Cruise: Disney Destiny

☐ None of these

☐ Still deciding

What made you pick that one?

Or what is making it hard to pick.

What would make it perfect?

A dinner, a spa day, a room upgrade, a photographer, anything.

Is anything a dealbreaker?

Long flights, connections, rain risk, no seaweed, whatever it is. Say it now.

How do you feel about the money?

☐ Spend what it takes

☐ The range shown is fine

☐ Let us keep it tighter

☐ Want to talk about it

Are the dates right?

October 1 to 4. Could we leave a day earlier or come back a day later?

Anything else on your mind?

Nothing sends until you tap one of those. Your answers stay on your phone until then.

Prices are published ranges and October averages, not live quotes for our exact dates, so the final number will move a little. Both passports are current, so nothing is blocking us. Palafitos has only thirty bungalows and we are about three and a half weeks out, so whichever way you lean, sooner is better.

Put together September 6, 2026.